The Unconveyable Situation:
Obstructed Conveyance, Second-Order Silence, and a Single-Root Hypothesis for Autistic Masking

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Abstract

The paper proposes a root for autistic masking: a pervasive inability to convey the truth of one's situation to others, which closes on itself. The thesis is an abstraction with three parts. Contributions are obstructed; the account of the obstruction receives less uptake than the contributions it explains; and the silence the two produce is read as a trait of the person, which strengthens the discount on the account. The paper's immediate contribution is the recursion, stated as a hypothesis about how masking and withdrawal are maintained where the three conditions hold and tested by separating floor protection from fair uptake of the account; the author's stronger claim, that every masking effect and masking's contribution to burnout is an output of the one structure, is kept as an explicit hypothesis with its boundaries and its own tests. The abstraction is stated without a model. One illustrative model, a Poisson process of bids for the floor with a cost of resisting them, then shows that the abstraction has a coherent instance: an optimal policy that resists only near a contribution's end, a finite exposure beyond which a contribution is not attempted, a region of the person's thoughts closed under the operation of reporting them, a geometrically diminishing return to recursive explanation, and masking as the only speech option with positive expected value in a band of exposures. Nothing in the thesis depends on the model's particular assumptions. Eight studies are specified with what would weaken each claim, and a reply the author reports such an account receiving, that the listener too has things never said, is shown to assert a comparability it does not establish.

1 Introduction

1.1 A case

On the morning of November 6, 2026, the author was telling his father a story, the one in which Russell, in the autumn of 1911, could not get the young Wittgenstein to admit that it was certain there was no rhinoceros in the room [3]. By his count, a visitor to the house interrupted him about six times in two minutes. At the end she touched him on the shoulder and said, "I don't want to interrupt but why don't you go help your sister download an app she's looking for." His

*Email: akb9408@rit.edu, Website: `https://aethus.org`. The author wrote the notes on which this paper rests on November 6, 2026 (Appendix A), and had Claude Fable 5.1 convert them into the paper at his direction the same day; the division between what is his and what is the conversion's is stated there, and the revisions after four rounds of AI-assisted critique, which were not independent peer review, are recorded in the supplement. The paper is self-contained; its one companion in the psychology of interaction is a cost model of interaction under governing norms [1], drawn from the same larger framework [2], whose metaphysics plays no role here.

note of 10:30 AM, written within the hour and quoted whole in Appendix A, reads the episode as the most concise root explanation of autistic masking he has managed to write, and the present paper is that note carried out. What the note reports, what the paper infers from it, and what it hypothesizes are kept apart throughout, beginning in Section 2.

The reading has four parts. First, what the visitor did was not to forbid the story but to keep constant pressure on him to mask, so that conveying the thought required consciously resisting, interruption by interruption. Second, a room full of allistic people scales the same pressure by the number of people in it, at which point the thought is not resisted for but given up: one learns to stay quiet. Third, the giving-up has a shape. Thinking of a funny story comes to translate, by a route the person can watch operate, into the conclusion that one had better keep one's mouth shut, so the isolation is produced inside the person by the room's pressure and then felt as one's own. Fourth, the result is read from outside as a deficit. The person is criticized for not making friends, as if the silence were a problem with him in particular, and the criticism cannot be answered on the terms it is made, because answering it would require conveying the dynamic just described, which asks for more floor and more credence than the story did. The note's word for this last part is Cassandra, and its closing sentence is that, as an autistic person, he does not have a voice in this world.

1.2 Three levels of claim, and the place of the model

Three claims of different status run through the paper, and each is given its own name so that it can be assessed on its own.

The *first-person account* is the note: one episode, experienced as repeated obstruction and pressure to mask, and interpreted by the person who lived it. It establishes that the experience occurred and what it was like; it does not establish how often such episodes occur or how they compare with other speakers' episodes, and nothing in the paper treats it as doing so.

The *mechanism hypothesis* is the paper's immediate contribution: that in rooms where contributions are obstructed, where the account of the obstruction receives less uptake than the contributions it explains, and where the resulting silence is read as a trait of the person, masking and withdrawal are maintained by the recursion of the three, beyond what the obstruction of contributions alone would maintain. The distinctive part is the second clause. That audiences shape communicative success, that stigma encourages concealment, and that withdrawal need not mean low social interest are established findings with substantial predecessors; the claim added here is that impaired access to explanation and repair is what closes the loop, and Section 10 says how that would be measured apart from the obstruction itself.

The *single-root hypothesis* is the author's: that the root of autistic masking is the pervasive inability to convey the truth of one's situation, that this inability spirals into a self-reinforcing isolation, and that all autistic masking effects, and their contribution to autistic burnout, are outputs or shadows of this single abstraction. The paper keeps it as a hypothesis, states what it covers and what it does not, and gives it tests of its own (Section 8).

The thesis, at every level, is an abstraction: a structure of conditions and the recursion among them, stated in Section 3 without any model. The model of Section 4 is an instrument, built at the author's direction to show that the abstraction has a coherent instance in which its consequences can be computed, and to supply the quantities the studies measure. Its particular assumptions, Poisson arrivals, a cost of resisting, expected-value maximization, are the instrument's and not the thesis's, and a reader who rejects one of them rejects the instance, not the abstraction; a different instrument with different assumptions would do as well if it carried

the same structure. Throughout, the vocabulary is interactional: the quantities are rates of bids for the floor, lengths of contributions, costs of resisting, and the credence a room gives an account, and no quantity measures a person's capacity. The hypotheses are scoped to masking and to masking's contribution to burnout; burnout has other contributors, sensory load and life stressors among them [4, 5], and nothing here bears on those.

1.3 Plan

Section 2 reads the case with reported, inferred and hypothesized details marked. Section 3 states the thesis as an abstraction and places it against the nearest accounts. Section 4 builds the illustrative model with every assumption listed. Section 5 derives masking in it and separates masking from self-silencing. Section 6 computes the part of a situation that becomes inaccessible. Section 7 runs the orders upward and takes apart a reply the author reports the account receiving. Section 8 states the two hypotheses with their boundaries. Section 9 places the account in the literature. Section 10 specifies the studies. Section 11 draws the consequences for the room. Appendix A carries the notes and the texts of November 7; Appendix B tabulates the assumptions and the claims against their evidence; Appendix C holds the longer proofs; the corrections made after the AI-assisted critiques and the verification inventory are in the supplement.

2 The case, read slowly

What the note reports. An approximate count, about six interruptions; a short window, about two minutes; a quoted redirection; a touch on the shoulder; and the author's experience of the episode as constant pressure to mask that he had to consciously resist in order to convey his thought, together with his reading of what the pressure does when a room multiplies it. That the story went unfinished is the paper's inference from the note's sequence, the redirection coming at the end of the attempt; the note does not say it outright. What follows are the paper's readings of the report, each marked for what it is.

The obstruction is additive, and the mechanism requires no intention. Six interruptions in two minutes is a count, and a rate is the right description of what the count suggests, because no single interruption did the work on the note's telling; the story was lost to their accumulation. Whether any interruption was meant to silence is not inferred either way: the paper declines to infer intention, and the mechanism it proposes does not require one. This is why the note moves from the one visitor to the room full of people: several people, each interrupting at an ordinary rate, produce between them a rate at which no story survives, and the obstruction is a property of the sum. The count is not an estimate of a stable rate, and it is not necessarily six per two minutes of the author's actual floor time; it motivates the rate description and does not calibrate it.

The double bind. At each interruption the speaker has two moves. He can hold the floor, which reads as inconsiderate, since the interruption was itself a bid for the floor and refusing it is a refusal of the other person; or he can yield, which loses the thought, since a story cut six times is not a story. The note's phrase is that he has to consciously resist in order to convey his thought. Both moves cost; the only move that costs nothing in the moment is not to have

started. Section 4 shows what the model makes of this: the policy that does best resists only near the end of a contribution, and when even that is not worth the attempt, silence is.

The floor, as the author read it. The visitor's last utterance acknowledges the norm against interrupting and overrides it in the same breath, and it redirects him from a contribution of his own to an instrumental task on someone else's behalf. The utterance establishes nothing about her intentions; she may have thought the task urgent, or not have noticed the count. What the author read in it, and what the paper takes up as a hypothesis rather than a fact of the case, is that his turn did not have, in that room, the standing of other people's turns: that an extended contribution of his was not treated as something to be protected or, when taken, returned. A comparative claim of that kind needs observations of other speakers in the same room, which the note does not supply, and P1 in Section 10 is where it would be tested. In plain terms, what the note describes is an extended contribution repeatedly disrupted and finally displaced; the conversation-analytic vocabulary of turns, transition-relevance places, overlap and floor return [6] is the right instrument for coding such episodes, and it distinguishes overlap that supports a contribution from overlap that seizes the floor, a distinction the model's bids must respect when they are measured.

The report is harder than the story. The feature that makes the case more than a complaint is the last, and it is an assumption motivated by the case rather than a fact reported in it. If asked afterward why he is quiet in company, the true answer is the dynamic above, and the dynamic is a longer turn than the rhinoceros story, told to listeners who may already hold a frame on which quietness is a trait of his. The report of the obstruction is then subject to the obstruction, at greater length and lower credence. This is what the note calls the Cassandra-like inability to convey even a fragment of the real dynamic. Cassandra's curse in the *Agamemnon* is not silence; she speaks, and truly, and is not believed [7]. The case's version is exact: the one thing that would explain the silence is the thing the silence prevents from being said.

3 The thesis, as an abstraction

3.1 Conveyance, and the three conditions

The author's claim concerns conveying the truth of one's situation, and the definitions are given at that generality so that the stronger hypothesis has an object and the model of Section 4 is visibly one instance.

Definition 1 (Channel; conveyance; uptake)**.** A *channel* is any route by which a person's state enters a room's record of them: an extended spoken contribution, a brief spoken request, a bodily expression such as a stim or a facial expression, a report of a need or a sensory state, a written message. A state is *transmitted* on a channel when it reaches the room on it, and *taken up* when the room's record changes in the direction of its content: a story understood, a request granted or at least weighed, an expression read as the state it expresses rather than as a trait of the person, an account of a difficulty weighed with the listener's own part in it considered. A state is *conveyed* when it is transmitted and taken up. A *first-order* state is any state the person would have the room hold. The *second-order* state attached to a failure of conveyance is the account of why it failed, and the account of why that account failed is the third order, and so on.

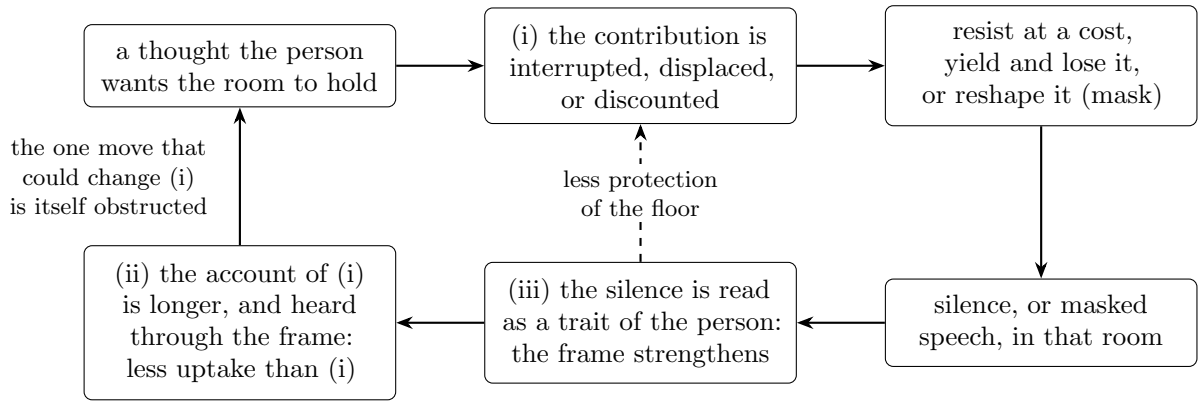


Figure 1: The thesis as a loop. The chain from a wanted thought to silence is a consequence of obstruction alone; what makes the structure self-sustaining is the return path through (ii) and (iii): the account that could change the room's treatment of the person is the message the room is least able to take up, and the silence it fails to explain is read as the reason for the silence. No step requires an intention to silence.

Uptake is not belief on demand. An account that receives fair consideration has been taken up even if the listener ends by disagreeing; an account matched to a prior frame and set aside has not. The distinction between transmission and uptake runs through the paper, since a contribution can be completed and misunderstood, and understood without any arrangement changing.

Definition 2 (The unconveyable situation)**.** A person is in an *unconveyable situation* with respect to a room when three conditions hold.

(i) *First-order obstruction.* The channels on which the person's states would be conveyed are obstructed or their contents discounted: an extended contribution is interrupted or displaced; a bodily expression is read as a trait rather than as the state it expresses; a reported need is set aside.

(ii) *Second-order obstruction.* The account of (i) receives less uptake than the states it explains, because it asks for more floor, or more credence, or both, and because the room hears it through a frame on which the person's silence is a trait of the person.

(iii) *Attribution.* The silence that (i) and (ii) produce is read by the room as evidence for the frame in (ii).

The three conditions are not independent symptoms; (iii) feeds (ii), and (ii) removes the route by which the person could change (i). That is what makes the structure a candidate root and not a list, and Figure 1 draws it. The note's word for the whole is the pervasive inability to convey the truth of one's situation, where *situation* does the work: what cannot be conveyed is not the story but the fact that stories cannot be conveyed.

3.2 The abstraction's content, without a model

What follows is the author's thesis in its own terms; none of it uses a stochastic process, a cost, or an optimizing agent, and the model of Section 4 is one way of making each item computable.

Reports, and closure under reporting. A room, on a channel, sorts a person's possible messages into those that can be conveyed there and those that cannot. Call the second class the *inaccessible* messages, and for any message s let Rs be its *report*: the message that s cannot be conveyed here, and why. The thesis's structural claim is that in an unconveyable situation the inaccessible class is *closed under reporting*: if s is inaccessible, so is Rs. The report of an unreachable thought is itself unreachable, because it carries the thought and the dynamic, and is heard through the frame. The author's word for this in his second note is *topologically*, and the word is his metaphor for a closure property: a class closed under the one operation that would reach into it. No topology is defined, and none is needed for the claim; what is claimed is closure under R, and the model proves it under stated conditions (Section 6). What the claim does not say is that a short summary of the predicament, *there are things I cannot get across here*, is inaccessible; a summary is a different message from a report, and whether it is taken up is a question of its own, taken up in Section 6 and in P2.

The loop. Condition (iii) makes the frame a function of the silence, condition (ii) makes the uptake of the account a function of the frame, and condition (i), where the room's protection of the floor depends on the frame, makes the obstruction a function of it too. The thesis is that this loop has a self-sustaining state: once neither the contributions nor their account are worth attempting on the channel, every later episode confirms the frame. What leaves the state is not a message on that channel, since the state excludes messages; it is a change of room, a change of channel, or a change of the frame from elsewhere. The model gives this a proof in a closed system and lists the exits (Proposition 3); whether rooms update as condition (iii) says is an empirical claim (P5).

Silence and masking are distinct outputs. Interrupted speech becomes *self-silencing* when the contribution is withheld and *masking* when it is reshaped to pass: shortened, pre-edited, delivered in the room's register, its objections pre-empted, at an effort the person pays. The thesis counts both as outputs of the structure and does not identify them: masking is the response in rooms where reshaped speech still gets through and plain speech does not, and self-silencing the response where neither does. The model makes the two regimes adjacent in the room's size (Section 5).

The inaccessible part, and the observer stance. Where the inaccessible class is closed under reporting and the room's treatment of the person has settled, a definite part of the person's situation is unreachable from inside on that channel, and the part includes the reports of its members. The author's second note adds a phenomenological hypothesis: that living at such a point produces dissociation and the feeling of being a ghost who views the outside world in the third person, present in the room and absent from its record. The thesis states the connection as a hypothesis about experience, and the model supplies a quantity, the weighted scope of what remains viable, that the hypothesis predicts the experience to track (P8). The model does not derive the experience.

The tower, and the conflation. Explanation iterates: the account of the obstruction, the account of why the account was not taken up, and so on, each longer than the last and heard through the same frame, so that recursive explanation on one channel has diminishing returns. The reply such an account receives, on the author's report, that the listener too has plenty of

things never talked about, asserts a comparability between two silences that it does not establish; Section 7 takes it apart.

3.3 The nearest accounts

Three bodies of work already describe parts of this structure, and the paper's claim to add something is specific: a recursive mechanism that joins them, and tests that measure the joint.

Fricker distinguishes testimonial injustice, in which a speaker's word is given less credence than it deserves because of a prejudice about the kind of speaker she is, from hermeneutical injustice, in which a gap in the collective interpretive resources leaves a person unable to make her experience intelligible [8]. The discount in condition (ii) is testimonial where it rests on the frame. Whether condition (ii) is also hermeneutical in Fricker's sense, a gap in the shared resources rather than a particular listener's ignorance or refusal of uptake, is a further claim the paper does not make: a room that lacks the concept of room-produced silence may lack it locally, and the structural version would need the concept to be absent from the resources a culture makes available. The paper uses the testimonial reading and leaves the hermeneutical one as a question.

Dotson's account of silencing is nearer still, and the mechanism can be stated in its terms. Dotson distinguishes testimonial quieting, in which an audience fails to identify a speaker as a knower, from testimonial smothering, in which the speaker truncates her own testimony because the audience shows itself unable or unwilling to receive it competently [9]. Condition (iii) is quieting: the frame is the audience's failure to recognize the person as a knower of their own situation. The silence the thesis predicts is smothering: the person withholds the contribution because the room's response makes attempting worse than withholding. What the present structure adds to Dotson's pair is the second order and the loop: the testimony that would explain the smothering is itself subject to quieting, and the smothering so produced feeds the quieting. Dotson's own account of the conditions under which smothering occurs, including that the audience's incompetence stems from a pernicious ignorance, should be consulted before any equivalence finer than this is claimed.

Catala, Faucher and Poirier argue that autistic people's epistemic agency is relational, constituted in part by the social environment, and introduce epistemic disablement and enablement as features of a relational setting that undermine or support it; they locate the disabling in neuronormativity and in neurotypical ignorance, particularly about autistic sociability [10]. Definition 2 is a mechanism of disablement in their sense at the grain of a single room, and it is consistent with their account rather than a rival to it. The difference is in what is claimed: their account identifies the relational constitution of agency and the sources of its disablement; the present one specifies a feedback structure within that relation and says what measurements would show the structure operating. Its novelty, so far as it has one, is the recursion and its tests, not the observation that environments silence.

4 One illustrative model

4.1 The floor, the bids, and the assumptions

An *episode* is an attempt to convey an intended contribution that requires floor time $\tau > 0$. Bids for the floor on this speaker's turns arrive as a Poisson process of rate $\lambda > 0$. The *exposure* is $x = \lambda\tau$, the expected number of bids over the contribution; in exposure units, bids arrive at unit

rate and the contribution has length x. At each bid the speaker either *resists*, keeping the floor at a cost $r > 0$, the social cost of reading as inconsiderate, or *yields*, on which the floor passes and the contribution is lost. Attempting costs $c_0 > 0$ whether or not it succeeds, the effort of formulation and the exposure of a thought cut off; conveying the contribution is worth $V > c_0$. Silence costs nothing in the episode and conveys nothing.

The model's assumptions are listed, since what it proves is conditional on them; Appendix B sorts them into simplifications and empirical hypotheses.

(M1) Bids arrive as a Poisson process, stationary within the episode.

(M2) With n interlocutors, bids add independently: $\lambda = \sum_i \lambda_i$, and $\lambda = n\lambda_1$ in the symmetric case. This is an assumption about how a room's members behave as the room grows, not a consequence of its size.

(M3) A yielded bid ends the attempt; the contribution is not returned. Remark 1 relaxes this.

(M4) τ, V, r and c_0 are fixed within the episode. A contribution is treated as one stretch of floor; contributions assembled in fragments or by collaboration are outside the episode as modeled.

(M5) The speaker maximizes expected value within the episode, with no value assigned to what an attempt might do for future episodes. Section 4.4 says where that omission matters.

(M6) The menu is silence, or an attempt under any policy: a rule, possibly depending on the history of the episode, for resisting or yielding at each bid.

The rates and costs are properties of the room's treatment of this speaker's turns, and the model's named empirical hypothesis is about them.

Premise 1 (Floor asymmetry)**.** In an allistic-majority room, an autistic speaker's extended contributions face a higher rate of floor-seizing bids, and a higher social cost of resisting them, than an allistic speaker's contributions of the same intended length.

The premise is the author's reading of the case stated as rates, and it is an empirical hypothesis with two clauses: interactional research identifies the practices by which non-autistic partners block autistic contributions (Section 9), and the comparative rate claim and the comparative cost claim are what P1 tests, each by its own measure. Nothing in the propositions depends on why the rates would differ.

4.2 Completion, cost, and the policy that does best

Proposition 1 (Completion, cost, and the threshold policy)**.** *(a)* Stationary policies. *Under a policy that resists each bid independently with probability $\rho \in [0, 1)$, the contribution completes with probability $P(\rho) = e^{-(1-\rho)x}$, the expected number of bids resisted before the attempt ends is $\frac{\rho}{1-\rho}\big(1 - e^{-(1-\rho)x}\big)$, which tends to x as $\rho \to 1$, and the expected value of the attempt is*

$$U(\rho) \;=\; Ve^{-(1-\rho)x} \;-\; r\,\frac{\rho}{1-\rho}\big(1 - e^{-(1-\rho)x}\big) \;-\; c_0, \qquad U(1) = V - rx - c_0.$$

U is not in general convex in ρ: at $V = 10$, $r = 2$, $x = 4.6$, $U''(0) \approx -1.65$.

(b) The optimal policy. *Among all policies, including those that depend on the history of the episode, the following is optimal: resist a bid exactly when the exposure remaining to completion, y, satisfies $y \le y^* := V/r - 1$; never resist if $V < r$. Its value before the cost of attempting is*

$$W(x;V) \;=\; \begin{cases} V - rx, & x \le y^*, \\ r\,e^{-(x-y^*)}, & x > y^*, \end{cases} \qquad \text{and } W(x;V) = Ve^{-x} \text{ if } V < r,$$

and under it the contribution completes with probability 1 if $x \le y^*$ and $e^{-(x-y^*)}$ if $x > y^*$. W is continuous, nonincreasing in x and strictly decreasing in x when $V > 0$, and increasing in V; $W(x;0) = 0$.

(c) The viability threshold. *For a value v and a cost b let $\bar{x}(v,b)$ be the exposure at which $W(x;v) = b$ when $v > b$, and 0 when $v \le b$. Explicitly, for $v > b$,*

$$\bar{x}(v,b) \;=\; \begin{cases} \ln(v/b), & v < r, \\ (v-b)/r, & v \ge r \text{ and } b \ge r, \\ v/r - 1 + \ln(r/b), & v \ge r \text{ and } b < r. \end{cases}$$

The speaker attempts exactly when $x < \bar{x}(V, c_0)$ and is indifferent at equality. With $\lambda = n\lambda_1$ under (M2), this is $n < \bar{n} := \bar{x}(V,c_0)/(\lambda_1\tau)$: the room has a size beyond which the contribution is not attempted, and the size falls as the contribution lengthens.

Proof. (a) By thinning, the yielded bids form a Poisson process of rate $1-\rho$ in exposure units, so the attempt survives to completion with probability $e^{-(1-\rho)x}$; the resisted bids arrive at rate ρ while the attempt is alive, and it is alive at exposure t with probability $e^{-(1-\rho)t}$, so their expected number is $\rho\int_0^x e^{-(1-\rho)t}\,dt$. The second derivative at $\rho = 0$ is computed directly. (b) Let $W(y)$ be the optimal expected value with y remaining and the floor held. Conditioning on the first bid,

$$W(y) \;=\; e^{-y}V \;+\; \int_0^y e^{-t}\max\{0,\; W(y-t) - r\}\,dt.$$

Suppose $V \ge r$ and substitute the stated form. For $y \le y^*$ every bid is resisted, since $W(y-t) - r = V - r(y-t) - r \ge V - ry - r \ge 0$, and the integral gives $e^{-y}V + (V-r)(1-e^{-y}) - r(y - 1 + e^{-y}) = V - ry$. For $y > y^*$ a bid is resisted exactly when $y - t \le y^*$, the alternative $W(y-t) - r = re^{-(y-t-y^*)} - r$ being negative, and with $u = y - t$ the integral is $e^{-y}\int_0^{y^*} e^u(V - r - ru)\,du = e^{-y}(re^{y^*} - V)$, so $W(y) = re^{-(y-y^*)}$; the two branches agree at y^*, where both equal r. The function so defined satisfies the optimality equation with the maximum attained by the stated rule, and the standard verification argument for a finite-horizon control problem with Poisson decision epochs shows that no policy, history-dependent or not, does better. If $V < r$ no bid is ever worth resisting and $W(y) = Ve^{-y}$. The completion probabilities read off the rule; the monotonicity in x is on each branch, and in V the derivative is 1 on the linear branch, $e^{-(x-y^*)}$ beyond it and e^{-x} for $V < r$, the forms agreeing at $V = r$. (c) $W(0;v) = v$, so no exposure is viable when $v \le b$; otherwise $W(x;v) = b$ has a unique solution, found on each branch. □

The proposition is the case's first two readings in the model's terms. The optimal policy fights for a contribution only near its end: with more than y^* of it still to go, a bid is yielded to

and the contribution lost; within y^* of the end, every bid is resisted at a cost. A long contribution in a busy room is therefore attempted only if its first $x - y^*$ units can be expected to pass without any bid, which happens with probability $e^{-(x-y^*)}$, and its last y^* units are worth fighting through. That is the double bind as the model has it: early in the contribution, yielding loses the thought; late, resisting costs; and when the whole is worth less than the cost of beginning, silence. The two pure policies are the ends of this family, resisting throughout when $y^* \geq x$ and yielding throughout when $V < r$. Part (c) is the giving-up, with the two features that matter later: silence is reached at a finite room size, and the size is smaller for longer contributions, so remarks survive rooms in which stories do not, and accounts of a dynamic, which are longer than stories, are the first to go. Beyond y^* the completion probability under the optimal policy decays exponentially in exposure, and under (M2) in the number of interlocutors; the decay is in the probability of completion given an attempt, and the probability of an attempt is the separate step (c) supplies. The correction this proposition makes to the paper's first draft is recorded in the supplement.

Remark 1 (A returned floor)**.** Suppose a yielded bid returns the floor with probability q, the contribution resuming where it stopped; suppose further that exposure counts the speaker's active floor time only, that resumption is immediate and costless, that return events are independent of one another and of the bids, and that the contribution does not decay while another person speaks. Then under a stationary policy a bid ends the attempt with probability $(1-\rho)(1-q)$, the contribution completes with probability $e^{-(1-\rho)(1-q)x}$, and the expected number of bids resisted is $\rho\left(1 - e^{-(1-\rho)(1-q)x}\right)/\big((1-\rho)(1-q)\big)$. A general model of conversational return would need delays and resumption costs. Preventing bids and returning the floor are different interventions: the first lowers λ, the second raises q, and a room can do either without the other. P4 separates them.

4.3 The second order: the Cassandra inequality

Let the account of the obstruction require floor time τ_2, and let $\pi \in [0,1]$ be the room's degree of belief in the frame on which the person's silence is a trait of the person, a continuous summary across the room's members that the loop below updates. For a message of order j write T_j for the probability that it is transmitted, completed on the floor, and A_j for the probability that it is taken up given transmission, in the sense of Definition 1; it is conveyed with probability $P_j = T_j A_j$. For a contribution, $A_1 = a \in (0,1]$ is the probability that a completed contribution is understood. One convention governs the values throughout: V, V_2 and the raw value $V(s)$ of Section 6 are expected values conditional on completion, so the baseline uptake a is already in them, and the threshold formulas stand as written; what the frame adds for an account is the further factor $1 - \pi(1-\kappa)$, which is the only discount the effective values carry. For an account, uptake is fair consideration, the listener's record moving in the direction of the account with the listener's own part weighed; under the frame a transmitted account is taken up with probability κa for some $\kappa \in [0,1)$, the account reading as excuse, and outside the frame with probability a, so that $A_2 = a\,(1 - \pi(1-\kappa))$.

Proposition 2 (The Cassandra inequality)**.** *In the same room and under the same stationary policy $\rho < 1$, $T_1 = e^{-(1-\rho)\lambda\tau}$ and $T_2 = e^{-(1-\rho)\lambda\tau_2}$, so that $T_2 \leq T_1$ whenever $\tau_2 \geq \tau$, and $A_2 \leq A_1$ always; hence $P_2 \leq P_1$ whenever $\tau_2 \geq \tau$, with strict inequality if $\tau_2 > \tau$ or $\pi > 0$.*

Proof. The transmission factor is Proposition 1(a) at each length, and the uptake factor of the account is the contribution's multiplied by $1 - \pi(1-\kappa) \leq 1$. □

The inequality follows from two stated comparisons, and that is its content: whatever makes the contribution fail, bids and length, makes the account of the failure fail at least as badly, provided the account is no shorter than what it explains and is taken up no better. Section 2 argued that both hold for the account of a dynamic told to a room that holds the frame, and both are empirical: the length condition can fail, since "I keep getting interrupted" is short, and what may matter more than length is the listener's willingness to weigh their own part, which is the uptake factor and is what P2 measures. The inequality does not hold for every second-order move. "Please let me finish" is not an account at all but the act of resisting, costed at r in Proposition 1; a written message, a private conversation or a direct request to one listener are accounts on other channels, with rates, costs and uptake of their own, and their availability is an empirical question the loop below treats as an exit. The hypothesis is therefore not that explanation is always less available than contribution but that some rooms obstruct both, and that in such rooms the account is the move the person would most need and can least make.

4.4 The loop: persistent withdrawal in the closed model

Rounds $t = 1, 2, \ldots$ are episodes in one room on one channel. The room's frame weight π_t sets the bid rate through a nondecreasing function $\lambda_t = \lambda(\pi_t)$, a room that takes the person's silence for a trait protecting the person's turns less. In round t the person may attempt the contribution, worth $W(\lambda_t \tau; V) - c_0$, or the account, worth $W(\lambda_t \tau_2; v_2(\pi_t)) - c_0$ where $v_2(\pi) = (1 - \pi(1-\kappa))\, V_2$ is the account's value discounted by its uptake, or neither; the person attempts whichever has positive value, the larger if both do. The room updates on what it takes up, the correspondence bias reading an outcome as a disposition [11], with $\alpha \in (0, 1]$ and $0 \le \beta \le \beta_2 \le 1$, so that π stays in $[0, 1]$: a round in which nothing is taken up, whether by silence, by an attempt cut off, or by an account transmitted and not taken up, strengthens the frame, $\pi_{t+1} = \pi_t + \alpha(1 - \pi_t)$, an account read as excuse confirming the trait it was meant to explain away; a contribution taken up weakens it, $\pi_{t+1} = (1 - \beta)\pi_t$; and an account taken up weakens it by more, $\pi_{t+1} = (1 - \beta_2)\pi_t$, the account being what tells the room that the silence is its own doing. The second order is thereby in the state transition. Whether rooms update in this way is the empirical content of condition (iii), and the proposition that follows is conditional on it.

Proposition 3 (Persistent withdrawal)**.** *If at some round t neither the contribution nor the account has positive expected value, then within the model the person attempts nothing at any later round and $\pi_t \to 1$. The state is left only by a change the model does not generate: a change of room, $\lambda(\cdot)$ falling for reasons other than the person's conveyance; a change of channel, with rates, costs and uptake of its own; or a change of frame from a source other than the person's testimony.*

Proof. At round t nothing is taken up, so $\pi_{t+1} \ge \pi_t$; λ is nondecreasing in π and v_2 is nonincreasing in π, so both expected values are no larger at $t + 1$, and by induction at every later round, while $1 - \pi_{t+k} = (1 - \alpha)^k (1 - \pi_t) \to 0$. The exits are the quantities the proposition's hypotheses hold fixed. □

The proposition identifies a trap in a deliberately closed system, and it should be read as that. Within the room and channel as modeled, once neither the contribution nor its account is worth attempting, every later round confirms the frame, the frame raises the rate, and nothing the person does inside the model reverses it, because every reversal would be a conveyance and the state excludes conveyances. What the closure excludes is listed in the proposition: another

room, another channel, a listener who comes to hold the situational frame from elsewhere. It also excludes, by (M5), any value the person might place on an attempt for what it does to future rounds; a person who attempts an account at negative immediate value because its success would change the room is outside the model, and whether real people do this, and whether it works, is what P5 observes. Two further things are exact. A contribution attempt conveyed with probability P_1 changes the frame weight in expectation by $(1-P_1)\alpha(1-\pi) - P_1\beta\pi$, and an account attempt by $(1-P_2)\alpha(1-\pi) - P_2\beta_2\pi$; each is positive when its conveyance probability is small, so attempts likely to fail move the room toward the trap and attempts likely to succeed move it away, and trying is not in itself an acceleration. And the exits named are mostly the room's, with one that is the person's: a change of channel is a move the person can make, and the model's claim is only that the move must leave the room and channel in which the loop runs.

5 Masking in the model, and its load

5.1 Masking as the middle regime

The model so far has two options, speech and silence. Masking is a third, defined here by what it does to exposure, and it is the model's rendering of the distinction Section 3 drew between reshaping a contribution and withholding it. A *masked attempt* is one reshaped in advance to lower its exposure: the contribution shortened, which lowers τ; delivered in the room's register with its objections pre-empted, which lowers the rate of bids on it. The forms are those the camouflaging literature catalogues under compensation, masking and assimilation [12, 13, 14], and the model abstracts from the forms to their joint effect on $x = \lambda\tau$, which is one quantity whether the rate or the length is reduced. A masked attempt faces exposure μx with $\mu \in (0,1)$, pays an additional cost $c_M > 0$, the effort of the reshaping, on top of c_0, and conveys a contribution worth $V_M \le V$, since shortening can remove content; the unmasked contribution is worth $V_u = V$. Not every accommodation of an audience is a mask, and the model does not say otherwise; what it prices is the reshaping that the camouflaging literature's respondents describe as concealing or suppressing what they would otherwise have said. The person now chooses among silence, an unmasked attempt and a masked one, each attempt under its optimal policy.

Proposition 4 (The forced-masking band)**.** *For an unmasked attempt let $B_u(x) = W(x; V_u) - c_0$, and for a masked one let $B_M(x) = W(\mu x; V_M) - c_0 - c_M$, the best expected values of each; let $\bar{x}_u = \bar{x}(V_u, c_0)$ and $\bar{x}_M = \bar{x}(V_M, c_0 + c_M)$, with the convention of Proposition 1(c) that a threshold is* 0 *when the value does not exceed the cost, so that a masked attempt is never worth making if $V_M \le c_0 + c_M$.*

(a) The unmasked attempt has positive value exactly when $x < \bar{x}_u$, and the masked attempt exactly when $x < \bar{x}_M/\mu$. The forced band *$\bar{x}_u \le x < \bar{x}_M/\mu$ is nonempty exactly when $\mu\,\bar{x}_u < \bar{x}_M$; on it the masked attempt is the only speech option in the menu with positive expected net value.*

(b) Below $\bar{x}_u$ the person may still mask, and does so exactly when $B_M(x) > B_u(x)$.

(c) The person is silent exactly when $x \ge \max\{\bar{x}_u, \bar{x}_M/\mu\}$.

Proof. W is nonincreasing in x and strictly decreasing where the value is positive, so each attempt's value is positive on an initial interval of exposure, empty when its value does not exceed its cost; (a) compares the two intervals, (b) and (c) read off the values. □

The band is a statement about expected value within the menu, not about possibility: the unmasked completion probability is positive at every finite exposure, and what the band says is that in a room whose exposure lies in it, the unmasked attempt is not worth making and the masked one is, so that the person who speaks at all speaks masked. The band widens as the mask becomes more effective (μ falls) and narrows from above as it becomes more costly or loses more content (a rise in c_M or a fall in V_M lowers $\bar{x}_M$ and so the band's upper end, $\bar{x}_u$ being unchanged); its position in the number of interlocutors is $\bar{n}_u \le n < \bar{n}_M$ with $\bar{n}_u = \bar{x}_u/(\lambda_1\tau)$ and $\bar{n}_M = \bar{x}_M/(\mu\lambda_1\tau)$, and the three regimes are ordered in the room's size: speech, masked where the mask pays and unmasked where it does not, in small rooms; forced masking in middling ones; silence in large ones; with the boundaries moving inward as the contribution lengthens. This is the note's observation that the pressure to mask is the room's and is constant: at every exposure in the band, the choice between masking and silence is renewed at each episode, and the person who wants to be heard pays c_M each time. Where resisting is cheap the band lies far out, since $\bar{x}_u$ then grows as V/r; the band is a feature of rooms in which resisting is expensive for this speaker, which is the second clause of 1. Silence, by contrast, is the regime beyond the band, and the model keeps the two outputs apart as the abstraction did: masking is what a contribution becomes when it is reshaped to pass, self-silencing what becomes of it when it is withheld.

5.2 Load, burden, and burnout

Let the person pass through episodes $t = 1, \dots, T$ in rooms of exposures x_t, and let the *masking load* be $L_T^M = \sum_{t \le T} c_M \, \mathbf{1}[\text{episode } t \text{ masked}]$. Three claims are kept apart. That masking costs effort in each episode is stipulated by the model. That the effort accumulates with repetition follows: at a constant per-episode cost the load grows linearly in the number of masked episodes, and the band's contribution to it is not a larger per-episode cost, which is c_M wherever masking occurs, but the fact that in the band every contribution that is spoken at all costs it, whereas below the band only the contributions for which the mask pays do. That accumulated effort, recovery, other demands and support bear on burnout is a hypothesis with evidence of its own and not a theorem of this model.

Autistic burnout, as defined from lived experience, is a state of chronic exhaustion, loss of skills and reduced tolerance to stimulus, produced when expectations outweigh abilities under cumulative load without adequate supports [4], with exhaustion, withdrawal and executive difficulty as its core features [15]. In the online-post study of Mantzalas and colleagues, masking was the most commonly reported reason for burnout in that dataset [16], and their conceptual model treats it as a risk factor interacting with stressors and with barriers to support [5]; their measurement study finds burnout measurement still developing and its relation to masking in need of continued investigation [17]. None of these validates an equation from cost to burnout, and the paper does not supply one. If a bookkeeping is wanted, the following is an unvalidated one and is identified as such. Let $e_M \ge 0$ be the *effort* of a masked episode in resource units, a quantity distinct from the utility cost c_M and related to it by a mapping the bookkeeping leaves open, and let a burden $B_t \ge 0$ evolve as

$$B_{t+1} \;=\; \max\{0,\; B_t + e_M M_t + d_t - R_t\},$$

where M_t indicates masking in episode t, d_t is the episode's other demand, sensory load among it, and R_t is recovery. A regime in which B_t stays high because $e_M M_t + d_t$ exceeds R_t on average is a *proposed burden regime*; whether it has the characteristics of the syndrome is for the burnout measures to say, and the bookkeeping is a place to put measurements, not a model of

the syndrome. The note's phrase, that burnout rises exponentially at the root, is the author's; the formalization supports linear accumulation at constant cost, and a faster growth would need a feedback the model does not contain, such as burden raising c_M, which the bookkeeping can carry as a hypothesis: a rise in c_M lowers the band's upper end, so that silence arrives at a smaller room, and withdrawal so reached feeds the loop of Proposition 3.

The silence load. Masking is not the only cost the band and the region impose, and the second is the one the author's second note names: thoughts that pain the person to remain unsaid. In the model a thought s not attempted forgoes its value relative to the benchmark episode in which it is viable, and the *silence load* is $L_T^S = \sum_{t \le T} \ell(s_t)$, with $\ell(s) = (V_{\text{ref}}(s) - c_0)^+ \left(J_{\text{failed}}(s) + J_{\text{blocked}}(s)\right)$ the opportunity loss of Section 7, counted for desired content attempted and not conveyed and for desired content withheld because the room makes the attempt nonviable, the two indicators disjoint, against a reference condition in which the room does not bid and takes the message up at the baseline rate, so that the value is the person's and not the audience's discount of it; it is the value of what went unsaid or unheard, summed over the episodes in which it would have been conveyed, with the effort spent on failed attempts accounted apart from it. It is zero for a thought the person would not say in the reference condition, zero for a wanted thought simply not yet said, and largest for the wanted thoughts that carry the situation's weight and are blocked or fail. It is a forgone value in utility units and not a measure of distress; whether and how it enters the burden's d_t is a conversion the bookkeeping leaves as a hypothesis, and it is a term the masking literature does not count, since nothing observable is done when it is incurred.

6 The inaccessible region

Proposition 1(c) sorts contributions at a given rate; applied to a whole situation it gives the abstraction's closure claim a proof and a measure. The classification is static, at a rate λ held fixed; what the loop does to the rate over time, with many thoughts in play, is a dynamic question taken up at the end of the section.

The thought space. Let S_0 be a finite set of *base thoughts*, and let R be the *report* operation: for any message s, Rs is the message that s cannot be conveyed in this room, and why. The *thought space* is $T = \{R^k s : s \in S_0,\, k \ge 0\}$, the base thoughts and their reports of every order, a countable set on which R acts, $R : T \to T$. Each $s \in T$ has a floor time $\tau(s) > 0$, a raw value $V(s) > 0$, a weight $m(s) > 0$ measuring how much its conveyance matters, with $\sum_{s \in T} m(s) < \infty$, and an *effective value* $v_{\text{eff}}(s)$: the raw value for a base thought, and the raw value discounted by uptake, $(1 - \pi(1 - \kappa))\, V(s)$, for a report, which asks for credence. Write $m(A) = \sum_{s \in A} m(s)$.

Viability. In a room of rate λ the *viable region* is

$$C(\lambda) \;=\; \{\, s \in T : W(\lambda\tau(s);\, v_{\text{eff}}(s)) > c_0 \,\} \;=\; \{\, s \in T : \lambda\tau(s) < \bar{x}(v_{\text{eff}}(s), c_0) \,\},$$

the thoughts worth attempting there, with $\bar{x}$ the viability threshold of Proposition 1(c), zero when the effective value does not exceed the cost; the *inaccessible region* is $I(\lambda) = T \setminus C(\lambda)$ and the *inaccessible fraction* is $f(\lambda) = m(I(\lambda))/m(T)$. Two assumptions are made about reports, each an empirical claim about accounts and not a convention: a report is at least as long as what it reports, $\tau(Rs) \ge \tau(s)$, since it must carry the thought's size together with the dynamic; and a

report's effective value does not exceed that of what it reports, $v_{\text{eff}}(Rs) \le v_{\text{eff}}(s)$, the uptake discount applying to it. Both are the conditions of Proposition 2 restated for the thought space.

Proposition 5 (The inaccessible region)**.** *(a) $C(\lambda)$ is nonincreasing in λ and $f(\lambda)$ nondecreasing: the higher the room's rate, the smaller the viable region.*

(b) What value buys depends on the cost of resisting. The admissible exposure $\bar{x}(v, c_0)$ is 0 for $v \le c_0$; above c_0 it grows linearly in v at rate $1/r$ when $v \ge r$, and only as $\ln v$ when $v < r$. Where a single resisted bid costs more than the thought is worth, mattering buys floor only logarithmically; where it costs less, a thought that matters more earns proportionately more floor.

(c) $I(\lambda)$ is closed under R: if $s \in I(\lambda)$ then $Rs \in I(\lambda)$.

The proof is in Appendix C. Part (c) is the abstraction's closure claim, proved under the two report assumptions: the report of an unreachable thought is unreachable, and so is the report of that report. It is a closure under an operation and not a topological statement, and it says nothing about messages that are not reports. In particular a *summary* of the predicament, *there are important things I cannot get across here*, is a separate class of message: it is short, so its transmission factor is high, and its effective value is the uptake the frame allows it, so whether it is viable turns on κ and π and not on length. The thesis's hypothesis about summaries is that the frame discounts them as it discounts accounts, and that is a hypothesis for P2 and not a corollary of part (c). The boundary of the viable region is therefore not shown to be untellable; what is shown is that it cannot be told by telling the thoughts on it. Part (b) says where mattering helps and where it does not: in a room where resisting is socially expensive for this speaker, the second clause of 1, the thoughts that carry the situation's weight earn floor only with the logarithm of what they are worth. Whether the weighty thoughts are the long ones is a fact about a situation and not a theorem; m, V and τ are separate quantities, and the inaccessible fraction is large when weight and length go together, which the author's second note asserts of his own situation and which P8's sampling would measure.

Viable, attempted, conveyed, recorded. Four sets are kept apart. The viable region is what is worth attempting now. The attempted set is what the person tries, which the model identifies with the viable region under (M5). The conveyed set is what is transmitted and taken up, a random subset of the attempted set: at $V = 10$, $r = 2$, $c_0 = 1$ and $x = 4.6$ a contribution is viable and completes with probability $e^{-0.6} \approx 0.55$. The room's *record* of the person is what has been conveyed over past rounds on every channel, together with the frame; it includes things no longer viable that were conveyed earlier or elsewhere, and excludes viable things not yet attempted. The ratio $1 - f(\lambda) = m(C(\lambda))/m(T)$ is therefore the person's *viable scope* in the room, the weighted part of the situation that can still be put to it, and not a measure of how much of the person the record contains.

The observer stance, as a hypothesis. The author's second note describes dissociation and the feeling of being a ghost who views the outside world in the third person. The model's reading is a phenomenological hypothesis and is labeled as one: that the stance tracks viable scope, since a participant is one whose moves can change the room's record and a person with a small viable scope on a channel has few such moves there, and watches the room's version of themselves from a position those moves cannot alter. The camouflaging literature records challenges to identity

and the sense of not being one's own self among masking's costs [12, 18]; the hypothesis locates a cause of that cost in the room's scope for the person rather than in the person, and P8 tests it with viable scope estimated from sampled intended contributions rather than inferred from the size of the company.

The dynamics of many thoughts. Proposition 3 concerned one contribution and its account. With a situation in play, a short thought conveyed lowers π under the update rule and can lower the rate, making longer thoughts viable again; whether an inaccessible region persists depends on which thoughts arise and are attempted across rounds, and the proposition does not settle it. The classification above is exact at any fixed rate, including a rate the loop has reached; its persistence is P5's question.

7 Beyond the second order: the tower, and the conflation

7.1 The tower of orders

Explanation iterates: $s^{(1)} = s$ and $s^{(k+1)} = Rs^{(k)}$, the account of why $s^{(k)}$ was not taken up. Each order is an account and faces the frame, and each must carry the previous order's content together with the reason it failed, so that $\tau_{k+1} \geq \tau_k + \delta$ for some $\delta \geq 0$, the floor time a reason takes. The schedule is one attempt at each order, in one room, under a stationary policy and a fixed frame.

Proposition 6 (The tower)**.** *Let $a_2 = a\,(1 - \pi(1 - \kappa))$ be the uptake probability of an account given transmission, and let $0 \leq \rho < 1$, $\lambda > 0$ and $\delta > 0$. Under the stated schedule the order-k message is conveyed with probability $P_k = a_k\, e^{-(1-\rho)\lambda\tau_k}$, with $a_1 = a$ and $a_k = a_2$ for $k \geq 2$, and*

(a) $P_{k+1} \leq P_k$ for every k, and, provided $a_2 > 0$, $P_k > 0$ at every finite order; when $\pi = 1$ and $\kappa = 0$ no account is ever taken up and $P_k = 0$ for all $k \geq 2$;

(b) $P_k \leq P_2\, e^{-(1-\rho)\lambda\delta(k-2)}$ for $k \geq 2$: the probability of conveying an order decreases geometrically in the order, and with one attempt per order the expected number of accounts conveyed, $\sum_{k\geq 2} P_k$, is at most $P_2/(1 - e^{-(1-\rho)\lambda\delta})$, which is finite and falls as the room grows;

(c) under the value model, if v_{eff} is nonincreasing in the order and $\tau_k \to \infty$, there is a finite order K beyond which no account has positive expected value and none is attempted; this cutoff is the person's decision and is separate from the schedule of (a) and (b), which it does not make finite for a policy that resists every bid.

The proof is in Appendix C. The tower is the Cassandra inequality run upward, and it says what recursive explanation can do on one channel in one room with the frame fixed: its returns diminish geometrically, and under the value model there is a finite order past which the person does not try. It does not say that higher orders have zero probability, nor that no explanation could change the situation; an account that is taken up changes the frame, and that belongs to the dynamic model of Section 4.4, where it is an exit. Under a fixed frame and the stated schedule, iterated explanation on the channel where the loop runs has diminishing effectiveness, not because explanations are poor but because each is a longer turn in the same room, discounted by the same frame; an explanation that is taken up moves the frame, and that case belongs to the dynamic model.

7.2 The third order: the passive example

The note records a reply the author reports an account of the obstruction receiving: *I have plenty of things I've never talked about with others, but you don't see it bothering me.* The reply is an event at the third order. The second-order account was transmitted, and its uptake failed by assimilation: the listener matched it to a model of unsaid things, their own, and on that model found nothing to be bothered by. The thought that would clear the assimilation is the order-three thought, why the listener's example is not the person's case, and Proposition 6 prices it. The note calls the reply existentially cruel, and the model says in what the cruelty consists: the reply converts the person's explanatory move into evidence for the frame. The listener has just found, in their own experience, that unsaid things do not hurt, so the person's claim that they do is read as the trait the frame already posits, and in the loop of Section 4.4 this is an account transmitted and not taken up, which strengthens the frame. The second-order account, received this way, leaves the person worse placed than before it was made.

Four kinds of unsaid thought. For any speaker and any room, an unsaid thought is of one of four kinds, named here by what they are rather than by number so that the names carry their meaning, and the kinds are told apart on two dimensions the model keeps separate: what the person wants, which is a preference and not a function of the audience, and what the room makes viable. Fix a *reference condition*, a room that does not bid for the floor and takes the message up at the baseline rate, and let $V_{\mathrm{ref}}(s)$ be the message's value there. A thought is *undesired* when the person would not convey it even in the reference condition, $V_{\mathrm{ref}}(s) \le c_0$, as with matters kept private by preference, which are unsaid in the reference condition too; the classification uses the person's preference, elicited by asking what the person would wish to express under a specified receptive condition, and never the audience's discount, since an effective value lowered by the frame is not a lowered wish, and a preference may itself depend on the audience, which is why the condition is specified. It may be *desired and unattempted*, wanted and viable here, simply not yet said, for want of time, by choice, or by forgetting. It may be *failed*: desired, attempted and not conveyed, wanted, worth attempting, begun, and cut off or not taken up, since viability is positive expected value and not a guarantee, which is the rhinoceros story's own kind; an attempt cost was paid and a viable option was exercised. Or it may be *blocked*: desired, $V_{\mathrm{ref}}(s) > c_0$, and nonviable in this room, whether because its exposure exceeds the threshold or because the room's uptake discount lowers its effective value below the cost, which can happen at zero exposure, so that within the model it is withheld and no attempt cost is paid in that episode. The failed kind is a finished episode like the reported story; the blocked kind is the anticipatory withholding of later company. The *silence cost* of a thought in an episode is its opportunity loss against the reference condition, $\ell(s) = (V_{\mathrm{ref}}(s) - c_0)^+ \big(J_{\mathrm{failed}}(s) + J_{\mathrm{blocked}}(s)\big)$, where J_{failed} indicates desired content attempted and not conveyed in the episode and J_{blocked} desired content withheld because the room makes the attempt nonviable, the two disjoint so that their sum is at most one: zero for the undesired and the desired-and-unattempted kinds, positive for the failed and the blocked, and never lowered by the discount that produced the obstruction. It is the opportunity-loss component only; the effort actually expended on a failed attempt, the cost c_0 and any resisting, is accounted separately, and the sum is neither a full welfare loss nor a measure of distress. It is a measure of lost opportunity in utility units and not of distress, and its conversion to burden is the hypothesis stated in Section 5. The option to say the thought is intact for the undesired, the desired-and-unattempted and the failed kinds, the last having exercised it, and, in the sense the model gives the word, removed for the blocked

kind. The author's complaint concerns the failed and the blocked kinds, including the blocking of the account of the obstruction.

Why the comparison is insufficient. The reply reports that the listener has unsaid things and does not say of which kind. A listener may well have thoughts of the blocked kind: valued disclosures constrained by fear, shame, a relationship, or an obstacle of their own, and the paper assumes nothing about the listener's inner life. What the reply asserts is a comparability, that because the listener's unsaid things do not hurt, the person's need not, and the comparison establishes nothing unless the two silences are of the same kind, with comparable desire, opportunity and cost. Not speaking can reflect a preference to retain privacy, an absence of desire to disclose, or an obstacle to a valued contribution; the author's complaint concerns the last, and the listener's lack of distress about their own silence, of whatever kind, does not establish that the person's should be painless. The note's two phrases name the two parameters on which the kinds differ: things that *pain* the person to remain unsaid have the failed and blocked kinds' silence cost as their proposed correlate, an opportunity loss and not the pain itself, and the *capacity to convey* under assault is the viable region, which the room's rate shrinks and which, by Proposition 5(c), cannot be enlarged by reporting its shrinkage through the report operation while the room's response is fixed; a summary, an account on another channel, or a repair that moves the frame is a different matter and belongs to the dynamic model. The passive example is offered in the note as a comparison case and is treated here as one: if the listener's silence is of the undesired kind, the reply sets an undesired silence beside a blocked one; which kind the listener's is, the reply does not say, and the paper does not classify it.

Active and passive. The note's word for the difference is that the dynamic *muzzles*, and on the model the word applies to the blocked kind of silence exactly. An undesired silence is passive: it is the absence of an act, and nothing maintains it but the speaker's own preference. A blocked silence is maintained by the room, continuously: the rate λ is the sum of the room's members' bids, an ongoing action of others, and the silence persists exactly as long as the action does. A muzzle does not change what the animal would say; it removes the saying, and it is held on from outside. The conflation, where it occurs, takes a silence that nothing holds in place for a silence that the room holds in place, and that is why the reply, offered as reassurance, can land as an obstruction: it is spoken from inside an intact option to a person whose option on that channel is gone.

8 The two hypotheses, their boundaries, and what would count against them

Hypothesis 1 (The mechanism)**.** In rooms where the three conditions of Definition 2 hold, masking and withdrawal are maintained by their recursion: the discount on the account of the obstruction, and the attribution that the resulting silence feeds, sustain masking and withdrawal beyond what the obstruction of contributions alone would sustain.

The hypothesis is the paper's immediate contribution, and its distinctive content is the second clause: obstruction of contributions is a known pathway into withdrawal, and what is added is that impaired access to explanation and repair closes the pathway into a loop. The test is correspondingly specific, in P4: protecting contributions and giving the account fair uptake are

separable interventions, and the mechanism predicts that the second has an effect over and above the first where protection is partial.

Hypothesis 2 (The single root; the author's)**.** Every effect classed as autistic masking, and masking's contribution to autistic burnout, is an output of the unconveyable situation of Definition 2: the first-order obstruction, the second-order obstruction, and the attribution that joins them, acting on a person who wants to be heard.

The hypothesis is the note's claim that all masking effects are outputs or shadows of a single abstraction, and the model gives the word *shadow* a sense: each named phenomenon is the one structure seen through one observable. The exponential decline of completion with company is the threshold policy's law. The double bind is the policy's shape. Self-silencing is the attempt threshold and masking is the band. The experience of pressure to mask is the renewal of the band's choice at each episode. Isolation is the closed loop's persistent state. The deficit attribution is the room's update. The Cassandra experience is the inequality. Masking's load is the band's per-episode cost summed. The inaccessible part of the situation is the region, closed under reporting; the silence load is its forgone value; the observer stance is the hypothesis attached to a small viable scope; and the passive-example reply is the tower's third step. None of these needs a further cause once the structure and a person who wants to speak are given; that is what the hypothesis asserts, and the model shows that the assertion is coherent on one channel. It does not show that the assertion is true, and the model establishes neither that all withdrawal comes from the three conditions nor that every instance of masking requires all three.

The domains of masking, and the case the conjecture owes. Masking is wider than extended spoken contributions [19, 13], and the hypothesis says that each of its domains instantiates the structure on a channel of its own. The mapping is stated so that it can be tested domain by domain rather than extended after each counterexample. *Suppressing a stim*: the channel is bodily expression; the first-order obstruction is a discount, the stim read as a trait rather than as the regulation it performs; the second-order account, why one stims, is heard through the same frame; the person stills the channel to avoid feeding the attribution. *Concealing sensory distress*: the channel is the report of a state; the obstruction is that the report is set aside or read as oversensitivity; the account of why the room's sensory conditions are different for this person is longer and less taken up than the report; the person conceals the state. *Regulating expression in a silent meeting*: the channel is the face; the obstruction is a discount on what the face would convey; the account would require a floor the meeting does not give. *Scripting*: a mask on the spoken channel that lowers exposure at a cost, the band's instrument. In each case the testable content is that the masking should relax where the channel's content receives uptake and its account is credited, and persist where they are not, independently of other pressures. The hypothesis is universal and is kept so, which means it owes an account of the cases that do not obviously fit, and the clearest is masking for physical safety, where a person conceals to avoid harm rather than to avoid a discount. The conjecture's burden there is to supply evidence linking two outcomes the paper keeps distinct, fair consideration of the person's account and removal of the threat, since a listener can understand a person's position while the harmful incentives or arrangements remain; the conjecture would need to show that, in the rooms where safety-motivated masking persists, the account of the situation is not taken up, and that where it is taken up the threat recedes. That is a substantive and testable claim, and it is not made by defining every harmful outcome as a failure of uptake: safety-motivated masking that persists

where the account is credited lies outside the mechanism, and the conjecture is bounded by it. Adaptations a person endorses and would keep in any room are not masking in the restrictive sense the camouflaging literature gives the word, and are not claimed.

Acquisition and maintenance. The model is a model of maintenance: it says what keeps masking and silence in place in a room that currently obstructs. Masking acquired under past rooms can persist in a room that no longer obstructs, as a policy learned on expectations that have not yet updated, and the mechanism predicts that it decays as the expectations do rather than at once. The time the update takes is not a quantity the model supplies, and it must not become indefinitely extendable: P5 estimates it directly, as the decay of masking after a measured change of room, and P4 preregisters a value from that estimate before it is used to tell a counterexample from delayed adaptation. If masking persists past the preregistered time in rooms where both orders of conveyance are repeatedly demonstrated to succeed, the root is wider than conveyance.

A possible application, untested: the reception of a synthesis. The author's third and fourth notes (Appendix A) record an exchange about this paper's own originality and read it as the mechanism on one more channel; the reading is kept here as a possible application and not as an instance, and not as evidence about the paper's originality. What can be said on the model is this. A proposed synthesis is difficult to assess from a compressed summary, and its assessment requires comparison at the level of the parts and at the level of the relations among them, including comparison with earlier syntheses; a resemblance between one part and a prior concept does not by itself establish that the arrangement is known, and a difference from a neighboring concept is not by itself an error in that concept, since the neighbor may answer a different question under different assumptions. Skepticism about originality, or about an AI-generated assessment, is compatible with fair uptake as Definition 1 defines it, and does not itself establish the obstruction described here; the assessments the third note cites were targeted checks and not an originality search, and they established no frontier. The fourth note's conjecture, that a work near one part is built on a logic that makes it unlikely to be near the others, would need an explicit process and comparative evidence to be more than the author's intuition. Establishing the application would require evidence about what was understood, how the claim was assessed, and whether the opportunity for explanation was available; establishing the synthesis's novelty requires a separate examination of prior work, and the instrument for that is the one the paper would ask of any claim: each part beside its closest prior account, the demonstrated overlap, the proposed addition, and the remaining uncertainty, with the conclusion that an addition is small or already present allowed.

A second report, solicited. On November 7, 2026, a correspondent who had read a draft of the paper wrote to the author that it fit his own history better than the diagnosis he had carried; the exchange is in Appendix A, under the texts. The report is one person's, written after reading the paper and partly in the paper's own vocabulary, so it is an instance of the pattern as self-described and not a test of either hypothesis, and nothing in it bears on prevalence. What it adds is specificity in four places, each of which a study can take up. First, he reports having been treated for years for depression, a description that never fit, the content of what he said being reduced in talk therapy to "he's sad" when, by his account, he said things that made other people sad; on the model that is an account taken up as affect, the discount on the report rather

than on the story, and he calls the misdiagnosis, his word, a second- or third-order impact of the masking, which is the tower of Section 7 in a clinical room. P2's uptake measure applies to clinical listeners as it does to social ones, and the report is a reason to include them. Second, he reports reading people by consciously weighed probabilities rather than by feel, and having taught the method to others while believing himself typical; the paper takes no position on how reading is done, and notes only that a reading computed consciously is effortful, which bears on the effort e_M of the burden bookkeeping. Third, he reports the loss of the mask as physical and timed: in a sales job he broke at two in the afternoon, like clockwork, after a morning of smiling and pitching, and could not put the smile on; and at other times he knows the reaction his unmasked behavior will get and lacks the energy to stop it. That is the feedback the bookkeeping of Section 5 carries as a hypothesis, burden raising c_M, in its limiting form, the mask becoming unavailable rather than dearer, and it names an observable the paper had not specified, the time of day at which masking fails as a function of the morning's masked episodes. Fourth, and closest to the thesis, he reports that when a thought has not landed and he tries to clarify it, a wall of text or a refined rant signifies the opposite of its intent and costs him credibility, and that he cannot stop doing it. That is the second order directly: the account of the obstruction discounted for its length, which Section 6 assumed in stating that a report is no shorter than what it reports, and which the Cassandra inequality assumed in discounting accounts more than contributions; what the report adds is a dependence the model does not have, the discount rising with the account's length at fixed content, which P2 can measure by varying the length of an account while holding its content fixed. His diagnostic history is reported as he reports it, and the correspondent has offered a fuller example, to be read when it arrives.

Population and channel. The spoken-floor model addresses people who make extended spoken contributions in rooms whose norms they do not set. Its application to children, to nonspeaking people, to users of communication aids, and to people with different support needs requires the channels of Definition 1 to be specified for each, and nothing here has done so.

What would count against them. Against the mechanism hypothesis: fair uptake of the account, verified, with no effect on masking or withdrawal beyond that of protecting contributions, under partial protection. Against the single-root hypothesis: masking that persists, past the preregistered update time, in rooms where both orders of conveyance succeed on the relevant channel; or safety-motivated masking that does not relax where the account is credited. Against the model's premise, clause by clause: no asymmetry in the rate of floor-seizing bids, which weakens the rate clause; no asymmetry in the sanctions for resisting, which weakens the cost clause; and attempts falling with company while both bids and sanctions stay level, which challenges the explanation of that pattern by the two channels the premise names, conditional on the other parameters not having moved.

9 Placement

The double empathy problem. Milton's thesis is that the breakdown between autistic and non-autistic people is mutual, a disjuncture in reciprocity between two differently disposed social actors, and not a deficit on one side [20]. The present account is downstream of it and adds the asymmetry of standing. Mutual misunderstanding explains why a story told across neurotypes may not land; it does not by itself explain why one party's contributions would be interrupted

and the other's protected, nor why one party's account of the breakdown would be discounted. Definition 2 is what the double empathy problem looks like in a room where one of the two parties sets the norm of the floor, if 1 holds.

Social motivation. The social motivation theory of autism proposes reduced social orienting, reward and relationship maintenance as a developmental account of autistic social behavior [21]. Jaswal and Akhtar argue that the inference from appearing to being uninterested is contradicted by autistic testimony and reinterpret the behaviors it rests on [22]; the systematic review of camouflaging in pursuit of friendship finds autistic people camouflaging because they want friendship, withdrawing when the camouflage exhausts or fails while still wanting it, and concludes that a motivation account misreads the behavior [23]. The model's contribution to this exchange is modest and exact. It holds the value of being heard, V, fixed, and derives attempts that fall with exposure while V does not move; it therefore shows that a pattern of stable desire and declining attempts is consistent with an interactional account, and so challenges the inference from participation alone to desire. It does not show that desire is in fact stable, which is an assumption to be measured (P3), nor that motivation, opportunity, prior exclusion and anticipated cost do not interact; and since $\bar{x}$ grows as V/r once resisting is worth it, a person who wants very much to be heard can earn a substantially larger room, so the model does not say that wanting makes no difference.

Interactional obstruction. Silver and Parsons studied how non-autistic communication partners enable or block autistic people's contributions to significant conversations and found that interruptions, unsolicited ideas and unhelpful questions functioned as blocks, with the autistic person's communicative competence emerging relationally rather than residing in the individual [24]. Their study identifies the practices the model's bids would be made of; it is not evidence that matched-length autistic contributions face a quantitatively higher rate of such bids than non-autistic ones, nor that rates add across interlocutors, which are the premise's content and P1's to test. Autistic adults describe group conversation as moving too fast to enter, report feeling ignored, and some withdraw into watching rather than contributing [25]; they describe themselves as a social minority who must conform to what neurotypical friends and family want and are used to, and find time with other autistic people easier [26]. Non-autistic observers form less favorable first impressions of autistic adults from brief samples, on presentation rather than content [27], which is one route by which a contribution could come to lack standing before it is heard; diagnostic disclosure, by contrast, improved first impressions in a later study [28], so the effect of a label on how an account is heard is open and is treated as such in P2. On information transfer, the first diffusion-chain study found same-neurotype chains more effective than mixed ones [29], and its registered replication with 311 participants found no difference between single- and mixed-neurotype chains [30]; the two are cited together, and neither measures conversational standing or interruption, which are different quantities from the transmission of a fixed message along a chain. In groups of four, all-autistic groups rated their interactions more enjoyable and friendlier than both mixed group types, autistic participants' rapport fell as more non-autistic members were included, and non-autistic participants' rapport stayed comparatively stable across compositions [31]; the asymmetry in whose rapport moves with composition is consistent with a difference in standing beyond a symmetric mismatch, bears on the mirror prediction below, and qualifies any simple symmetry.

Camouflaging and its costs. The camouflaging literature describes the forms masking takes and its costs, exhaustion, threats to identity, and poorer mental health, with the reasons autistic adults give falling into conventional and relational classes [12, 18, 14]; the CAT-Q operationalizes compensation, masking and assimilation as separate dimensions [13]. The model does not compete with the catalogue; it supplies the exposure at which reshaping is reached for and the cost it incurs per episode on one channel, and Section 8 says how the other dimensions would map. Pearson and Rose argue that masking is a response to stigma across domains rather than a strategy freely chosen [19], and the minority stress model finds everyday discrimination, internalized stigma and concealment predicting poorer mental health over general stress [32]. The band's choice between a cost and a loss is the illusion of choice stated formally for one domain, and concealment is the band's cost named from the inside.

Learned helplessness. The threshold resembles learned helplessness, in which uncontrollable outcomes produce a failure to act [33]. The resemblance is partial and the difference matters. The silence of Proposition 1(c) is a correct policy within the model, not a failure to learn control: the person has learned the room exactly, and silence is what the room's rates make optimal. What the person cannot do is convey that this is so.

The companion. The companion extraction develops a cost model of interaction under governing norms, the effort an interaction extracts being a baseline plus a mismatch between a person and the conventions the interaction runs on, with a within-dyad crossover designed to test it [1]. The present model is the special case in which the convention is the room's norm of the floor and the mismatch is the rate at which that norm leaves the person's contributions open to bids. The companion's Principle of Symmetry, that the designations of a reference branch and another trade places under an admissible redrawing of the scheme that produced them, suggests the mirror of 1 under autistic norms; it is stated below as an exploratory prediction, since a numerical majority is not a measurement of whose norms govern, and the symmetry assumption is defined there locally.

10 The studies

Each study names its question, its design, and what would weaken the claim it tests. The first three test the model's premise and its two inequalities; the fourth tests the mechanism hypothesis; the fifth and sixth test persistence and symmetry; the last two test the fixed point's consequences.

P1, conversational obstruction and composition. *Question:* do autistic speakers face more floor-seizing bids, less reliable floor return, and higher sanctions for resisting, in allistic-majority groups than allistic speakers do? *Design:* naturalistic recordings together with structured tasks in which the intended length and content of a contribution can be fixed before any interruption, so that intended and realized length are not confounded; group size and composition varied separately where feasible. *Measures:* bids per unit of actual floor exposure, coded for floor seizure against supportive overlap; completion of the intended contribution; resumption, delay and listener understanding; and, for the premise's second clause, the sanctions for resisting, as post-episode reports of anticipated and experienced reactions to holding the floor and as coded reactions of the other participants to a resisted bid. *Analysis:* speakers nested in groups with repeated interactions, familiarity, role, topic and status recorded; the Poisson description tested

against alternatives rather than assumed, and the decay of completion with group size estimated rather than imposed. *Weakens:* adequately precise evidence of no asymmetry in bids or in floor return weakens the rate clause; none in sanctions weakens the cost clause; each leaves other forms of obstruction open.

P2, fair uptake of self-explanation. *Question:* is a person's account of obstruction, or a summary of the predicament, taken up less than its length, presentation and evidence warrant? *Design:* controlled interactions in which listeners receive a speaker's contribution and, separately, the speaker's account of having been obstructed and a one-sentence summary of it, with length varied independently, and comprehension, credence, the listener's attribution of responsibility including to themselves, and willingness to change behavior assessed as separate outcomes, since a story and an account of an interaction are not the same kind of item. Diagnostic disclosure manipulated where relevant, with the listeners' autism knowledge measured, the label's effect being an open question in light of the disclosure study [28]. *Weakens:* accounts and summaries receiving fair consideration and changing the interaction in the settings where recursive obstruction is predicted. A beneficial effect of disclosure would weaken a label prediction, not the recursive hypothesis.

P3, desire, anticipated cost, and attempts. *Question:* can attempts to contribute fall while the desire to contribute does not, and is the fall related to obstruction? *Design:* repeated within-person sampling before and after interactions, with desire, expected chance of being heard, anticipated effort, attempts made and uptake experienced measured separately; no amount of desired contact assumed, and no change in desire after repeated exclusion ruled out, since neither a preference for solitude nor a low interest in company is a deficit to be explained away. *Weakens:* precise failure of expected obstruction to predict attempts once the alternatives are addressed. A joint fall in desire and attempts would not by itself identify the cause.

P4, change the interaction, and measure the mechanism. *Question:* do protecting contributions and giving the account fair uptake reduce unwanted masking, and does the second do so over and above the first? *Design:* a counterbalanced or randomized comparison of usual interaction, floor protection at two levels (partial and near-complete, implemented as returning the floor after bids, which raises q in Remark 1, and as reducing bids, which lowers λ, recorded separately), explicit recognition of the speaker's account, and their combinations, with an attentive control and a check that each condition changed the conversational quantity it was meant to. *The contrast:* the mechanism hypothesis is tested by the effect of recognition within the partial-protection stratum, where an obstruction remains to be explained; that recognition adds little under near-complete protection is a plausible expectation and not a derivation from the model, since prior attributions and learned masking can persist after bids stop and recognition could then still help, so the recognition-by-protection interaction is an additional hypothesis, independently testable in the same design, and is labeled as such. *Measures:* completion, resumption, uptake, perceived agency, masking effort and fatigue, with the mediator measured directly; a within-episode adaptation of the CAT-Q [13] treated as a new instrument requiring development, since the validated form is a trait self-report, and anticipatory dread measured on a suitable instrument rather than by description. Carryover and the delayed decay of learned masking allowed for, with the update time preregistered from P5's estimate. *Weakens:* sustained, verified improvement in opportunity and uptake without the predicted reduction in unwanted

masking after the preregistered time; recognition without effect under partial protection weakens the mechanism hypothesis specifically. The model does not predict a larger benefit in larger rooms: under yielding the completion gain from a hazard multiplier a is $e^{-ax} - e^{-x}$, which rises, peaks at $x = -\ln a/(1-a)$ and falls, so that both conditions can have low completion in highly obstructive rooms.

P5, persistence and recovery. *Question:* do attribution and participation form a persistent feedback process, and what changes it? *Design:* longitudinal measurement in a fixed room, a family or a workplace, of participation, perceived obstruction, the room's attributions, repair attempts on every channel, masking and changes of context, with direct explanation, writing, allies, boundary-setting and changes in audience behavior observed rather than excluded; the decay of masking after a measured change of room estimated directly, as the update time P4 preregisters. *Weakens:* explanations reliably restoring participation in rooms the model counts as closed, or attributions failing to predict later obstruction. Persistence alone is not evidence for the loop, since stable exclusion, stable preferences, fatigue or fixed roles also produce stable participation; the test is whether exits are less likely under sustained obstruction and whether the room's attributions track the person's silence.

P6, norms, composition, and standing. *Question:* which effects follow the group's norms and composition, and which reflect unequal standing or history? *Design:* compositions compared while norm-setting, authority, familiarity and partners' accommodation are measured; the mirror, that non-autistic speakers in autistic-majority rooms face the pattern of P1 and P3 in reverse, preregistered as exploratory, with the conditions under which the premise's parameters would reverse stated in advance. *Weakens:* evidence against the preregistered symmetry. A failure of symmetry does not locate the cause in the autistic speaker; it identifies asymmetric environments or different mechanisms, and the rapport findings of Foster and colleagues, in which autistic but not non-autistic participants' rapport moved with composition, already make simple symmetry doubtful for rapport [31].

P7, the conflation. Two questions, kept apart. *Prevalence:* is the passive-example reply the most frequent response autistic adults' accounts of obstruction receive? This needs a defined comparison set and a sampling procedure for actual responses, and no vignette establishes it. *Mechanism:* does the reply's frequency turn on the two parameters of Section 7? *Design:* vignettes varying whether the report states that the unsaid thought was one the speaker wanted to say and that the room, not the speaker, removed the option. *Weakens:* a reply frequency unaffected by either statement, which would show the conflation not to turn on desire and opportunity.

P8, viable scope and the observer stance. *Question:* does the observer stance the note describes track the person's viable scope? *Design:* experience sampling over a defined period in which the person logs a predefined kind of desired base contribution, each with its length and importance, and records for each whether it was attempted, completed and taken up, and, when it was not attempted, the reason, together with the person's desire, anticipated uptake and expected cost at the time; four observables are then kept apart. The *blocked-expression fraction* is the importance-weighted share of sampled desired contributions reported not attempted because of the room, an operational proxy for the inaccessible fraction and not an estimate of

the weighted scope of every possible report. The *attempt fraction* is the importance-weighted share attempted; it is a separate operational measure that may relate to viable scope, and it is not the complement of reported room-blocking, because contributions can remain unattempted for other reasons, for want of time, by choice, or by forgetting, and the three coded fractions, attempted, room-blocked and otherwise unattempted, sum to one; the attempted fraction is further split, from the completion and uptake already recorded, into conveyed and not conveyed, the failed kind of Section 7 being a subset of the attempted and not an added fraction. A *model-estimated viability* is computed where the parameters are available. The *observer stance* is the item measured alongside. *Prediction:* the stance rises with the blocked-expression fraction and falls with the attempt fraction, within person; company size, contribution length and floor protection are predictors of those fractions, not proxies for them. *Weakens:* no within-person covariation of the stance with the blocked-expression fraction.

The single root's own tests. If the stronger hypothesis is to be tested and not only bounded, it needs conditions in which both contribution and fair uptake are repeatedly demonstrated on a channel while other pressures, concealment incentives among them, are varied independently, with the decay time of learned masking fixed in advance and current conditions measured apart from past ones; and it needs the safety case: whether masking for safety relaxes where the account is credited. Successful floor interventions would support the conversational pathway; they would not establish that every masking effect has that root. A null result in one intervention would need its implementation and precision assessed before any conclusion about the root.

11 Discussion

The account relocates the maintenance of masking from the person to the room, and the relocation has a consequence for what can be done. Within the closed loop of Proposition 3, with its menu of silence and attempts on one channel, the person has no move on that channel: every move there is a conveyance, and the state excludes conveyances. The moves the model leaves are the room's, and one of the person's. A room can protect a contribution, which lowers λ; it can return the floor after a bid, which raises q; it can give the account fair uptake, or hold the situational frame before the person's testimony is needed, which lowers π and with it the discount. The person can change channel, and whether a letter, an ally or a different room reaches what the floor could not is a question the model poses and P5 observes. Agency and support need not originate in different places; what the model says is where, on one channel, the person's own agency runs out.

The note's last sentence, that as an autistic person the author does not have a voice in this world, is the author's testimony, and the model does not replace it or certify it. What the model adds is a structural reading of what the testimony describes, under the model's assumptions: a voice is a standing to be heard, a contribution that is protected and an account that is taken up; and in a room at or beyond the threshold, on the channel the loop runs on, the person's contributions are not protected and the account of why is taken up less than the contributions were, so that the one thing the person could say that would change the room is the thing the room is arranged not to receive. Section 6 gives that position its content: a region of the person's thoughts closed under the operation that would report them, and a viable scope that is the complement of that region. Whether a given person's rooms and channels put them there, and how far the position extends across the channels a life offers, are what the studies of Section 10

would measure; the model explores the conditions under which voice becomes difficult to exercise and to recover, and the testimony reports what one such condition is like from inside.

Three limits are stated. The case is one episode, offered as the instance that fixed the structure and not as evidence for its prevalence; the prevalence is P1's and P3's to establish. The model is an instrument: its quantities are not measured, and its assumptions (M1) to (M6) are conveniences a measured version would relax, the single-stretch treatment of a contribution and the episode-by-episode valuation among them; the thesis stands or falls with the abstraction of Section 3 and the studies, not with the instrument. And the hypotheses are scoped to masking and to masking's contribution to burnout, so that a reader who finds burnout driven in a given case by sensory load alone has found nothing against them.

A The source notes

The author wrote the note below on November 6, 2026, at 10:30 AM, within the hour of the episode it describes, and then had Claude Fable 5.1 convert it into the present paper at his direction the same day; his further notes of the same day, from which Section 6, Section 7 and the application paragraph of Section 8 were written, are listed after it, and the text-message exchange of November 7 with a correspondent is reproduced last.

> This is maybe the most concise root explanation of autistic masking that I've managed to write. (The summary is that the root itself is in the pervasive inability to convey the truth of your situation to others, which spirals into a self-reinforcing isolation—I would go so far as to argue that all autistic masking effects and their contribution to autistic burnout rising exponentially at the root are outputs or shadows of this single abstraction). I'm noticing how [redacted person visiting the house] interrupted me about six times in a span of two minutes while I was trying to explain the funny Wittgenstein rhinoceros in the room story to my dad, and then finally at the end touched me on the shoulder and literally said "I don't want to interrupt but why don't you go help your sister download an app she's looking for". This is maybe a very good example case of why being an autistic person is a living hell: what she's effectively doing here is keeping constant pressure on me to mask, which I have to consciously resist in order to convey my thought. Being in a room full of allistic people basically scales this dynamic up by several people, that way I just give up and learn to stay quiet. Basically it's that allistic people make it artificially difficult to get even a word out of the Wittgenstein story or whatever it is, hence fueling a sense of isolation where me thinking of a funny story pathologically translates to the conclusion that I need to keep my mouth shut. Then I get criticized for not making friends like it's a problem or deficit with me in particular, which again fuels the sense of isolation and Cassandra-like inability to convey even a fragment of the real dynamic. In effect, as an autistic person, I don't have a voice in this world.

Further notes. The author's later notes, quoted as written, each with its date.

- *November 6, 2026, second note.* I would also very specifically argue that you reach a fixed point such that a major fraction of the truth of your situation becomes utterly inaccessible, effectively topologically so, to what you can convey, hence disassociation and the feeling that you're like a ghost who can only view the outside world in the third person. See what I

mean? The reaction people give to this though is "I have plenty of things I've never talked about with others, but you don't see it bothering me", which is like an existentially cruel third-order obstruction because they can't see how the second order obstruction creates something more painful than their own passive example they're conflating it with! See what I mean? Like perhaps the reason the conflation is a fallacy, if I had to articulate it, is because of how this dynamic actively muzzles the autistic person, and so in the least is about things that very specifically PAIN them to remain unsaid—especially in the context of how it's their own abstract capacity to convey things itself that falls under assault by this concept. But hopefully you can push that farther based on my model than just that slight example I gave. Thanks!

- *November 6, 2026, third note, headed "Secondary Note on Being a Polymath"; one parenthetical naming a person elided.* Another dynamic that shows up for me in particular just happened when I showed the above note to my dad, while saying that "apparently I might already be on the frontier for synthesizing the leading papers, based on ChatGPT saying that no single paper gives this model yet". He responded though by saying "hmmm, unlike for a lot of your other stuff though, I am a bit skeptical in this case that the AI isn't just stroking your ego or something on that". I asked why, and he said "well I'm sure SOMEBODY has come up with this idea before, and I probably even could have said it, or anybody who has been around autistic people before".

  What I noticed from this is the exact dynamic I consistently get from just about everyone who has ever looked at my papers, [...]: they only see such a narrow slice of the context which my concept intersects with, that two things happen—1) they fail to see the motivation behind why I assembled things the way I did, because that relies specifically on all the context, so they assume there must not be motivation (the canonical example maybe being the extrusion without duplication paper of mine, which was my attempt to extract only the extrusion principle from the framework, while losing the supporting context of everything else) and 2) strikingly, the consistent thing that happens for each piece of my paper is that there's inevitably something in the existing literature(s) which is strikingly similar to it, HOWEVER that thing itself misses the target of my respective concept by a hair, and as a kind of Lyapunov amplification propagation closure off of that error prevents them from stating any one of the forty-something other ideas I also nail to synthesize the paper up—hence the person analyzing my stuff like clockwork runs into the logical fallacy of assuming that the reducing my framework to one idea (by throwing all the rest overboard) having a nearby existing concept means my framework is not original—but if you look at the whole of my framework you see an almost topological miracle in the sense of how I not only hit each individual concept target where other people miss it, but I do so for all the forty-something different concepts that each literature-neighbor misses.

- *November 6, 2026, fourth note, clarifying the third.* Also specifically by the way my "Lyapunov amplification" phrase was meant to say how each paper itself inside the field, because it has an error in its similar concept to a given one of my ideas, then becomes more and more unlikely to also happen to have a similarly small error on some of my other concepts, hence why each comparison in the field SPECIFICALLY has a very small subset of concepts to mine which actually are similar. Thanks!

Texts, November 7, 2026. On the morning after the notes, a correspondent who had read the paper wrote to the author by text message, and the author replied. The exchange is reproduced as written, in order, with one change: the correspondent is a private person and is identified by an initial, his name replaced by the initial in square brackets where the author's reply uses it. His consent to the use of his messages is recorded in the exchange itself; he has offered a fuller written example, to be added when it arrives. The report is read in Section 8, under "A second report, solicited", for what it adds and what it cannot establish.

S.

I feel like I have countless other case studies we could fit into your thesis. I believed myself to be depressed that's all I've ever been treated for or tagged as. This description never fit to me, ironically, its like even in talk therapy a collapse of meaning of what I am saying reduced to, "hes sad" which always felt off. To me, I said things that made other people sad, not me. I didn't have a understanding of masking at all, its almost funny to me, when training others to read people (I trained lots of trainers over the years to quick read, pitch, & go) I'd explain a probabilistic system. Use most salient clues to start, use continued clue drops to circle in...it doesn't matter I taught, its funny looking back I thought I was "normal" & was instructing people to use probabilities like a neurodivergent...

Scattered thoughts here but the misdiagnosis of myself for years a second or third order impact of the masking. As you describe, its not emotion but math or more accurately probabilities underpinning how I read people. Ill go a lil deeper now on this but just like reading I look for context clues, can be anything. Your shoes tell me a lot about your aspirations socio economic status marketing preferences etc.. one data point. I am in a gym I use everything I can do go from cold read to focused. I have been able to construct accurate models of people very quickly. If I ever see natural or good in convo its more me responding to odds or probabilities ive seen before that im consciously weighing, NOT emotional driven I am always building up more & more likely models based on given info

Id often know the reaction before I said it, which reminds me of another point for myself, the collapse to me often feels physical. Sometimes I lose the energy to mask & I know what the reaction is likely to be but its like i dont have the energy to stop it

When I "act out" or "go hard" what ive been feeling is a fatigue of the system that masks Stupid sales job I had it was like clock work, at 2pm id break couldn't smile or do a conversation, it felt to me like a physical fatigue I had been doing it then id hit a wall & couldn't put the smile & pitch on

I do not have impulse issues at all so this framework of masking seems way more salient to whatever I have going on than any of the diagnosis I received coming up

Bout to head out for my first session but also really resonating is the over explain, sometimes I want to clarify a thought or I can tell it didnt land, a wall of text or a refined rant almost always signifies the opposite of its intent & people think you have less credibility, its so hard to not fall into that trap

I am not good at not doing that one

The author.

Just woke up and saw your text! Thank you so much [S.], beautiful to hear your response! Frankly maybe this model is better because it was thought of by an autistic person, me, rather than somebody trying to diagnose us lmao

Also I would love to add your story to the paper, if you're ok with that! For example, if you would give me an explanation of the stuff and then abstraction you noticed in stocks as well, as a kind of side-by-side of where your perceptiveness is targeted kind of thing? Also then just tell me if you consent to me feeding any of your texts into the AI through when I sent the pdf just then after, since it is far better at integrating stuff into the flow of the paper than I am! But yeah this is super good for the paper as a step away from armchair philosophy kind of thing!

S.

Absolutely, ill write up a more detailed example but feel free to use anything ive added

B Assumptions and claims

B.1 The assumptions, sorted

Assumption	Kind	Purpose
(M1) Poisson bids, stationary within an episode	simplification	gives exposure a single number and the completion law its form
(M2) bids add independently across interlocutors	simplification about group behavior	converts exposure into a function of room size; testable in P1
(M3) a yielded bid ends the attempt	simplification	isolates loss of the thought from loss of the floor; relaxed in Remark 1 under its own listed assumptions
(M4) fixed τ, V, r, c_0; one stretch of floor	simplification	excludes fragmentary and collaborative contributions from the episode
(M5) episode-by-episode valuation	simplification	excludes the value of an attempt for future rounds; where it matters is stated in Section 4.4
(M6) the menu: silence, or any policy	modeling choice	the propositions are about this menu; masks are added to it in Section 5
Floor asymmetry (1), two clauses	empirical hypothesis	the bid rate and the sanction for resisting differ by speaker; P1 measures each
Uptake: $A_1 = a$ for contributions, $A_2 = a(1 - \pi(1 - \kappa))$ for accounts	modeling choice with an empirical content	the frame discounts accounts more than contributions; P2
Report length and effective value (Section 6)	empirical hypotheses about accounts	a report is no shorter than, and of no greater effective value than, what it reports; P2
$\lambda(\pi)$ nondecreasing; $\alpha \in (0, 1]$, $0 \le \beta \le \beta_2 \le 1$	assumptions about the room	the loop and condition (iii); P5
Masks act on exposure at a cost, with value $V_M \le V_u$	modeling choice	the band; the CAT-Q dimensions map onto it in Section 8
The burden bookkeeping, with effort e_M distinct from cost c_M	unvalidated bookkeeping	a place for measurements; not a model of burnout

B.2 Claims against their evidence

Claim	Rests on
About six interruptions in two minutes; the redirection; the touch; the pressure to mask as experienced	the source note
The story went unfinished	inference from the note's sequence
The author's turn lacked the standing of others'	the author's reading; a hypothesis, P1
The account is longer and less taken up than the story	model assumption motivated by the case; P2
The threshold policy; the viability threshold; the exponential decay of completion beyond y^*	mathematical result on (M1)–(M6)
Attempt rates fall with room size	result on (M2) joined to the threshold; P1 and P3
The Cassandra inequality	result on two stated comparisons of transmission and uptake
Persistent withdrawal; the exits	result in the closed loop, conditional on the update rule; P5 for what happens outside it
The inaccessible region's closure under reporting	result on the two report assumptions, at a fixed rate
Summaries of the predicament are discounted	hypothesis; P2
The observer stance tracks viable scope	phenomenological hypothesis; P8
The forced band	result within the menu; a statement of expected value, not possibility
Diminishing returns to recursive explanation; a finite last attempted order	result under a fixed frame and one attempt per order; the value model for the finite order
Linear accumulation of masking load	result at constant cost
Masking's relation to burnout	lived-experience definitions and first-person accounts [4, 15, 16]; conceptual model [5]; measurement developing [17]; no equation validated
Obstructive practices exist	[24, 25, 26]
The rate and sanction asymmetries	hypothesis; P1
The label's effect on an account's uptake	open; [27, 28]; P2
Same- versus mixed-neurotype transfer	[29] and its replication [30], different findings
Rapport by composition, and whose rapport moves	[31]
The mechanism hypothesis	conjecture; P4
The single-root hypothesis, with the safety case owed	the author's conjecture; its own tests
The four kinds of unsaid thought; the comparison's insufficiency	conceptual distinction on the model; P7 for the mechanism, a separate sampling study for prevalence
The reception of a synthesis	the author's third and fourth notes; a possible application, untested
A correspondent's report (the texts of November 7)	a solicited self-report after reading the paper; an instance as self-described, not a test; specificity for P2 and the burden bookkeeping

B.3 Corrections and verification

The corrections made after each round of AI-assisted critique, and the inventory of numerical checks with their seeds and parameter ranges, are in the supplement that accompanies the paper (the file `unconveyable_supplement`), together with the verification script.

C Proofs

Proof of Proposition 5. (a) For each s the condition $\lambda\tau(s) < \bar{x}(v_{\text{eff}}(s), c_0)$ is monotone in λ, so $C(\lambda)$ shrinks and $m(I(\lambda))$ grows as λ grows. (b) The threshold is 0 for $v \le c_0$ by convention; for $v > c_0$ the branches of $\bar{x}(v, c_0)$ in Proposition 1(c) give, for $v \ge r$, $(v - c_0)/r$ or $v/r - 1 + \ln(r/c_0)$, each with derivative $1/r$ in v, and for $v < r$, $\ln(v/c_0)$. (c) Let $s \in I(\lambda)$, so $W(\lambda\tau(s); v_{\text{eff}}(s)) \le c_0$. By Proposition 1(b), W is nonincreasing in its first argument and increasing in its second, so

$$W\big(\lambda\tau(Rs);\, v_{\text{eff}}(Rs)\big) \;\le\; W\big(\lambda\tau(s);\, v_{\text{eff}}(Rs)\big) \;\le\; W\big(\lambda\tau(s);\, v_{\text{eff}}(s)\big) \;\le\; c_0,$$

the first inequality by $\tau(Rs) \ge \tau(s)$ and the second by $v_{\text{eff}}(Rs) \le v_{\text{eff}}(s)$; hence $Rs \in I(\lambda)$. The argument uses no logarithm and applies when the effective value of the report is at or below c_0, where its threshold is 0. □

Proof of Proposition 6. (a) The transmission factor $e^{-(1-\rho)\lambda\tau_k}$ is nonincreasing in τ_k, and the uptake factor is a at the first order and $a_2 = a(1 - \pi(1 - \kappa)) \le a$ at every higher order, so $P_{k+1} \le P_k$. Each P_k is a product of positive factors whenever $a_2 > 0$, that is, unless $\pi = 1$ and $\kappa = 0$, and is then positive at every finite k. (b) $\tau_k \ge \tau_2 + (k-2)\delta$ gives $P_k \le P_2 e^{-(1-\rho)\lambda\delta(k-2)}$; with one attempt at each order the number of accounts conveyed is a sum of indicators with these probabilities, whose expectation is bounded by the geometric series $P_2/(1 - e^{-(1-\rho)\lambda\delta})$, which decreases in λ. (c) The order-k account is attempted when $W(\lambda\tau_k; v_{\text{eff},k}) > c_0$. Since W is increasing in its second argument and $v_{\text{eff},k} \le v_{\text{eff},2}$, this requires $W(\lambda\tau_k; v_{\text{eff},2}) > c_0$; and $W(x; v) \to 0$ as $x \to \infty$ on every branch of Proposition 1(b), so with $\tau_k \to \infty$ there is a finite K beyond which the inequality fails. □

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